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SUNDAY, FEBRUARY 15, 2026

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



A path to sainthood

By **Angie Leventis Lourgos**
Chicago Tribune

With a captivating voice and piercing eyes that seemed to penetrate the camera, the Illinois-born bishop explained the paradox of human suffering to millions of viewers on one episode of his acclaimed 1950s television show “Life Is Worth Living.”

Draped in a flowing ferraiolo and pectoral cross, Fulton J. Sheen declared that love has the ability to transform worldly burdens, paving the way for grace and redemption.

“Love will not kill pain. But love will diminish it,” Sheen, who would later be elevated to an archbishop, told his vast at-home audience of Catholics and non-Catholics alike. “A mother sits up with her sick child all night long. It is not agony. It is love. ... Love in the face of sorrow does not seek isolation. It wants to take on that pain as its own.”

Famed evangelist, TV host Archbishop Fulton Sheen to be the first beatified Illinois native

Bishop Fulton J. Sheen greets an admirer outside Holy Name Cathedral on Aug. 24, 1965, in Chicago. Bishop Sheen, of New York City, was attending the installation of Cardinal John Cody as the head of the Chicago Archdiocese. **CHICAGO TRIBUNE HISTORICAL PHOTO**

The groundbreaking prime-time weekly series surprisingly competed for viewership with secular heavy-hitters such as “The Frank Sinatra Show” and legendary comedian Milton Berle, who joked, “At least I’m losing my ratings to God.”

Airing in black-and-white, Sheen’s distinctive blend of humor and theology entranced viewers, earning him the 1953 Emmy Award for Most Outstanding Television Personality over stars of the era, including broadcaster Edward R. Murrow, actor Lucille Ball and comedian Jimmy Durante.

Upon acceptance, the cleric born and raised in the Diocese of Peoria credited his program’s success to its four writers: evangelists Matthew, Mark, Luke and John.

Catholic faithful continued to be touched by Sheen’s words and legacy

Turn to *Sheen*, Page 4

STATE OF THE STATE

Budget, Trump expected targets

Pritzker’s address could be shaped by political crosscurrents, fiscal math

By **Jeremy Gerner**
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — One year ago, Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker used his annual State of the State and budget address as a national platform to warn Illinoisans about President Donald Trump’s threats to democracy, likening Trump’s leadership to that of Nazi-era Germany.

On the eve of his next state-wide address in an election year where both he and Democrats hope to retake Congress, Pritzker is expected to deliver a speech shaped as much by political cross-currents as by fiscal math. It will likely present a more optimistic picture of Illinois’ finances than last fall’s estimate that the state faces a \$2.2 billion budget gap. It’ll also almost assuredly feature the governor doubling down on Trump, saying the Republican president’s first year of his second term only proved his predictions were accurate.

The governor himself hinted at the latter theme for the speech, scheduled for Wednesday before a packed Illinois House chamber, as he unveiled a new Substack with an inaugural blog post titled, “The State of Illinois is Being Loud for America: A Year of Confronting Donald Trump.”

“After I delivered the speech (last year), some people said I was being unfair or alarmist. One year later, it’s clear it really is a five-alarm fire. I still stand by every word,” the governor wrote. “Donald Trump deals in intimidation, but we aren’t afraid ... Illinoisans love this nation too much to let MAGA tear down our constitutional republic.”

While Pritzker’s expected

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INSIDE



CHRIS CODUTO/GETTY

‘He’s going to be pretty special’

Munetaka Murakami is fitting in at White Sox camp as his MLB journey begins. “Everyone’s really, really nice and welcoming.” **Chicago Sports**

DHS SHUTDOWN: TSA agents are expected to work without pay, and travelers may find security and flight delays. **Nation & World**

Human composting a way to return whence you came

Process offers an environmentally friendly end, and some are pushing to legalize it in Illinois

By **Adriana Pérez**
Chicago Tribune

Two summers ago, a newspaper article inspired Roxann Specht to write a detailed note containing her end-of-life requests. After sharing it with her husband, Gerald, he was similarly inspired but much more to the point.

Six words scrawled underneath her note would become his dying wish: “The same for me as well!”

Seven months later, Gerald Specht died unexpectedly at 75 after collapsing outside his Evanston home. Survived by his

wife and three children, Specht’s note referred to instructions not to bury or cremate his body but rather transform it into compost and return it to the earth — an increasingly popular, environmentally friendly alternative to handling human remains.

Not only is human composting affordable, but it also avoids the release of plumes of smoke from cremation and the leaking of fluids from burying embalmed bodies. In the United States, each year, cremation releases hundreds of thousands of tons of carbon dioxide into the atmo-

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Katrina Spade, the founder and CEO of Recompose, a company that uses composting as an alternative to burying or cremating human remains, displays a sample of compost material left from the decomposition of a cow using a combination of wood chips, alfalfa and straw on April 19, 2019, in Seattle. **ELAINE THOMPSON/AP**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High **57** Low **35**

Complete forecast on Opinion, Page 12

\$5.75 city and suburbs and elsewhere
178th year No. 46 © Chicago Tribune



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